

Κάνθαρος ὁ Κωμικός

Cantharus the Comic Poet and the Athenian Woman Choruses

eul_aid: dxo

Period: *Κλασική* Classical
Dialect: Ἀττική Attic (com, frg)
Domain: Κωμῳδία Comedy
Format: Ἑμμετρος Verse

Cantharus was an Athenian comic poet active in the 5th century BCE during the period of Old Comedy. Though obscure today, ancient records confirm he was a recognized competitor in Athens's major dramatic festivals. According to the Parian Marble, he won his first victory at the City Dionysia in 422 BCE. A later Byzantine source offers a different date for his career peak, but modern scholars generally consider the earlier inscription more reliable. This places him as a contemporary of more famous playwrights like Aristophanes.

His works have not survived intact. He is credited with two known play titles: *Tereus* and *Alcmaeon*. Both were comedies based on mythological figures, a common practice in Old Comedy known as mythological burlesque. A later source attributes six plays to him, but only these two titles are specifically attested elsewhere. What remains of his work consists only of fragments and references quoted by later authors.

Cantharus represents the many successful comic poets of his era whose plays are now lost. His recorded victory demonstrates the competitive and vibrant nature of Athenian theatre, which featured many playwrights beyond the few whose complete works survive. The fragments and records related to Cantharus help historians reconstruct the broader history and thematic range of Old Comedy.

Works (2)

- [Ἀποσπάσματα · Athenian Woman and the Chorus](#) · 6 passages
- [Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Ἀθηναίων Γυναικῶν · Fragments on Athenian Women](#) · 11 passages